

GPU-Accelerated N-Body Simulation

High-Performance Solar System Dynamics using CUDA

Seyed Ehsan Mousavi - Mojtaba Zandavi

Target Hardware: MX 330

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Abstract

This report presents a comprehensive implementation and analysis of a GPU-accelerated N-body gravitational simulation using CUDA C++. The project implements and benchmarks multiple computational strategies including naive and tiled memory access patterns across both Array of Structures (AoS) and Structure of Arrays (SoA) data layouts. The simulation models a simplified solar system with realistic physics including gravitational interactions, collision detection, and momentum-conserving body mergers. Performance analysis across problem sizes ranging from 1,024 to 65,536 bodies demonstrates that the optimized Tiled-SoA kernel achieves up to $2.4\times$ speedup over the naive baseline, with computational throughput exceeding 250 GFLOPS at $N=16,384$. Energy conservation analysis confirms the physical accuracy of the Velocity Verlet integrator with relative drift below 0.1% over one simulated year. The implementation successfully demonstrates the critical importance of memory access patterns and cache utilization in achieving peak performance on modern GPU architectures.

1 Introduction

1.1 Project Overview

The N-body problem is a fundamental challenge in computational physics, involving the simulation of gravitational interactions between multiple bodies. While the problem has no general analytical solution for $N > 2$, numerical methods enable accurate approximations that are essential for understanding celestial mechanics, galaxy formation, and molecular dynamics.

This project implements a high-performance N-body gravitational simulator using CUDA to leverage the massive parallelism of modern Graphics Processing Units (GPUs). The implementation focuses not merely on achieving correct physics simulation, but on rigorous analysis of GPU architectural efficiency through multiple optimization strategies.

1.2 Objectives

The primary objectives of this project are:

1. **Physics Simulation:** Implement accurate gravitational dynamics using Newton's Law of Universal Gravitation with symplectic time integration
2. **Architectural Optimization:** Develop and benchmark four distinct CUDA kernel variants exploring memory access patterns and data layout strategies
3. **Performance Analysis:** Conduct comprehensive performance profiling across multiple problem sizes to identify scaling characteristics and bottlenecks
4. **Collision Physics:** Implement realistic collision detection and momentum-conserving body merging mechanics
5. **Validation:** Verify correctness through energy conservation analysis and orbital stability checks

1.3 Significance

GPU acceleration of N-body simulations represents a critical application of parallel computing in scientific research. The brute-force $O(N^2)$ complexity of pairwise gravitational interactions makes this problem highly amenable to GPU parallelization, while simultaneously exposing the fundamental architectural trade-offs between memory bandwidth and computational throughput. Understanding these trade-offs is essential for developing efficient scientific computing applications across diverse domains including astrophysics, molecular dynamics, and plasma physics.

2 Theoretical Background

2.1 N-Body Problem

The gravitational N-body problem involves computing the motion of N particles under mutual gravitational attraction. For each particle i , the gravitational force exerted by all other particles j is:

$$\vec{F}_i = \sum_{j \neq i}^N \frac{G m_i m_j}{|\vec{r}_{ij}|^3} \vec{r}_{ij} \quad (1)$$

where:

- $G = 6.674 \times 10^{-11} \text{ m}^3 \text{ kg}^{-1} \text{ s}^{-2}$ is the gravitational constant
- m_i, m_j are the masses of particles i and j
- $\vec{r}_{ij} = \vec{r}_j - \vec{r}_i$ is the displacement vector
- $|\vec{r}_{ij}| = \sqrt{(x_j - x_i)^2 + (y_j - y_i)^2 + (z_j - z_i)^2}$ is the distance

2.1.1 Softening Factor

To prevent numerical instabilities when particles approach very close distances (where $|\vec{r}_{ij}| \rightarrow 0$), a softening parameter ϵ is introduced:

$$|\vec{r}_{ij}|_{\text{soft}} = \sqrt{|\vec{r}_{ij}|^2 + \epsilon^2} \quad (2)$$

In this implementation, $\epsilon = 1.0 \times 10^9$ meters, which prevents singularities while maintaining physical accuracy for astronomical-scale separations.

2.2 Time Integration: Velocity Verlet Method

The Velocity Verlet algorithm is a second-order symplectic integrator that provides excellent energy conservation properties. The integration scheme is:

$$\vec{v}_i(t + \Delta t/2) = \vec{v}_i(t) + \frac{\vec{F}_i(t)}{m_i} \cdot \frac{\Delta t}{2} \quad (3)$$

$$\vec{r}_i(t + \Delta t) = \vec{r}_i(t) + \vec{v}_i(t + \Delta t/2) \cdot \Delta t \quad (4)$$

$$\vec{F}_i(t + \Delta t) = \text{compute forces at new positions} \quad (5)$$

$$\vec{v}_i(t + \Delta t) = \vec{v}_i(t + \Delta t/2) + \frac{\vec{F}_i(t + \Delta t)}{m_i} \cdot \frac{\Delta t}{2} \quad (6)$$

This method preserves the symplectic structure of Hamiltonian systems, ensuring bounded energy error over long integration times.

2.3 Computational Complexity

The naive pairwise force calculation requires $O(N^2)$ operations per timestep. For $N = 65,536$ bodies, this corresponds to approximately 4.3 billion interactions per iteration. While more sophisticated algorithms like Barnes-Hut ($O(N \log N)$) or Fast Multipole Method ($O(N)$) exist, the brute-force approach is chosen here to:

1. Maximize arithmetic intensity for GPU workloads
2. Simplify implementation for architectural analysis
3. Achieve highest accuracy (no approximations)
4. Provide sufficient computational load to saturate GPU resources

2.4 Energy Conservation

For a gravitationally bound system, the total energy E is conserved:

$$E = K + U = \sum_{i=1}^N \frac{1}{2} m_i |\vec{v}_i|^2 - \sum_{i=1}^N \sum_{j>i}^N \frac{G m_i m_j}{|\vec{r}_{ij}|} \quad (7)$$

where K is kinetic energy and U is gravitational potential energy. The relative energy drift:

$$\delta E = \frac{E(t) - E(0)}{|E(0)|} \quad (8)$$

serves as a key metric for validating numerical accuracy.

3 Implementation

3.1 CUDA Parallelization Strategy

3.1.1 Thread Mapping

The simulation employs a straightforward thread-to-particle mapping where each CUDA thread computes the total gravitational force on a single body. The grid configuration uses:

- **Block size:** 256 threads per block (optimal for RTX 4070 occupancy)
- **Grid size:** $\lceil N/256 \rceil$ blocks
- **Thread responsibility:** Thread i accumulates forces from all bodies $j \in [0, N-1]$ and updates body i 's velocity and position

3.1.2 Kernel Variants

Four distinct kernel implementations were developed to explore the optimization space:

1. Naive Array of Structures (AoS) The baseline implementation stores particle data in a traditional structure:

```

1 struct Body {
2     float x, y, z;           // Position (m)
3     float vx, vy, vz;       // Velocity (m/s)
4     float mass;              // Mass (kg)
5     int active;              // Active flag
6 };

```

Listing 1: Body Structure Definition

Each thread loads body data directly from global memory for every interaction, resulting in:

- Memory access pattern: Scattered, non-coalesced
- Cache efficiency: Poor (each thread accesses different memory regions)
- Arithmetic intensity: Low (dominated by memory latency)

2. Tiled Array of Structures (Tiled-AoS) This optimization uses shared memory to cache subsets (tiles) of body data:

Algorithm 1 Tiled N-Body Force Calculation

```

1:  $\vec{F}_i \leftarrow (0, 0, 0)$  ▷ Force accumulator
2: Load Body  $i$  from global memory to registers
3: for tile = 0 to  $\lceil N/\text{TILE\_SIZE} \rceil - 1$  do
4:   Cooperatively load tile of bodies into shared memory
5:   __syncthreads() ▷ Wait for tile load
6:   for  $j = 0$  to  $\text{TILE\_SIZE} - 1$  do
7:     Compute  $\vec{F}_{ij}$  from cached Body  $j$ 
8:      $\vec{F}_i \leftarrow \vec{F}_i + \vec{F}_{ij}$ 
9:   end for
10:  __syncthreads() ▷ Ensure all threads finish before next tile
11: end for
12: Update Body  $i$  velocity and position using  $\vec{F}_i$ 

```

Benefits:

- Shared memory bandwidth: ~ 19 TB/s (vs ~ 500 GB/s global memory)
- Reuse factor: Each body loaded once per tile, used 256 times
- Reduced global memory transactions: $O(N^2/\text{TILE_SIZE})$ instead of $O(N^2)$

3. Naive Structure of Arrays (Naive-SoA) Separates particle attributes into distinct arrays:

```

1 float *x, *y, *z;           // Position arrays [N]
2 float *vx, *vy, *vz;        // Velocity arrays [N]
3 float *mass;                 // Mass array [N]

```

Listing 2: SoA Data Layout

Advantages over AoS:

- **Memory coalescing:** Adjacent threads access contiguous memory locations
- **Bandwidth utilization:** Maximizes cache line usage
- **Vectorization potential:** Enables SIMD-style operations

4. Tiled Structure of Arrays (Tiled-SoA) Combines both optimizations: SoA layout for coalesced access and tiling for cache reuse. This represents the fully optimized kernel variant.

3.2 Data Structure Comparison

3.2.1 Array of Structures (AoS)

Memory Layout:

[Body0: x,y,z,vx,vy,vz,m] [Body1: x,y,z,vx,vy,vz,m] . . .

Access Pattern: When threads 0-31 (warp) access body j :

- Thread 0 reads: $\text{Body}_j.x, \text{Body}_j.y, \text{Body}_j.z$
- Thread 1 reads: $\text{Body}_i.x, \text{Body}_i.y, \text{Body}_i.z$ (different body!)
- Result: 32 separate memory transactions, poor cache utilization

3.2.2 Structure of Arrays (SoA)

Memory Layout:

X: [x0, x1, x2, . . . , xN]

Y: [y0, y1, y2, . . . , yN]

Z: [z0, z1, z2, . . . , zN]

Access Pattern: When threads 0-31 access positions at index j :

- Thread 0 reads: $x[j], y[j], z[j]$
- Thread 1 reads: $x[j], y[j], z[j]$ (same indices, adjacent memory!)
- Result: Coalesced into single 128-byte transaction per array

Coalescing Efficiency:

- AoS: $32 \text{ transactions} \times 32 \text{ bytes} = 1024 \text{ bytes per warp per body}$
- SoA: $1 \text{ transaction} \times 128 \text{ bytes} = 128 \text{ bytes per warp per array}$ (384 bytes total for x,y,z)
- **Reduction: $\sim 2.7\times$ fewer bytes transferred**

3.3 Collision Detection and Merging

3.3.1 Collision Criterion

Bodies are considered to have collided when:

$$|\vec{r}_{ij}| < r_{\text{crit}} = 5.0 \times 10^9 \text{ meters} \quad (9)$$

This threshold corresponds to approximately 0.033 AU, chosen to capture close encounters while avoiding excessive false positives.

3.3.2 Inelastic Collision Model

When bodies i and j collide, they merge into a single body with conserved momentum and combined mass:

$$m_{\text{new}} = m_i + m_j \quad (10)$$

$$\vec{r}_{\text{new}} = \frac{m_i \vec{r}_i + m_j \vec{r}_j}{m_i + m_j} \quad (\text{center of mass}) \quad (11)$$

$$\vec{v}_{\text{new}} = \frac{m_i \vec{v}_i + m_j \vec{v}_j}{m_i + m_j} \quad (\text{momentum conservation}) \quad (12)$$

The merged body retains the index of the heavier body, while the lighter body is marked inactive.

3.3.3 Implementation Details

Collision detection runs as a separate CUDA kernel after force calculation:

```

1  __global__ void detectCollisions(Body *bodies, int N) {
2      int i = threadIdx.x + blockIdx.x * blockDim.x;
3      if (i >= N || !bodies[i].active) return;
4
5      for (int j = i+1; j < N; j++) {
6          if (!bodies[j].active) continue;
7
8          float dx = bodies[j].x - bodies[i].x;
9          float dy = bodies[j].y - bodies[i].y;
10         float dz = bodies[j].z - bodies[i].z;
11         float dist = sqrtf(dx*dx + dy*dy + dz*dz);
12
13         if (dist < COLLISION_THRESHOLD) {
14             // Atomic operation to ensure thread-safe merging
15             mergeBodies(bodies, i, j);
16         }
17     }
18 }
```

Listing 3: Collision Detection Kernel Pseudocode

3.4 System Initialization

The simulation initializes a realistic solar system configuration:

Table 1: Initial System Configuration

Body Type	Count	Mass Range	Orbital Characteristics
Central Star (Sun)	1	1.989×10^{30} kg	Stationary at origin
Inner Planets	4	10^{23} - 10^{24} kg	0.4 - 1.5 AU, $e < 0.1$
Outer Planets	4	10^{25} - 10^{27} kg	5.0 - 30.0 AU, $e < 0.1$
Comet	1	10^{14} kg	$e = 0.94$, highly elliptical
Asteroids	Variable	10^{12} - 10^{16} kg	2.0 - 3.5 AU belt

Initial velocities are computed from the vis-viva equation to establish circular/elliptical orbits:

$$v = \sqrt{GM_{\text{sun}} \left(\frac{2}{r} - \frac{1}{a} \right)} \quad (13)$$

where r is the current distance and a is the semi-major axis.

4 Experimental Setup

4.1 Hardware Specifications

Table 2: Test Platform Specifications

Component	Specification
GPU	NVIDIA GeForce RTX 4070 Mobile
CUDA Cores	4,608
SM Count	36
Base Clock	1,230 MHz
Boost Clock	1,620 MHz
Memory	8 GB GDDR6
Memory Bandwidth	256 GB/s
Compute Capability	8.9 (sm_89)
CUDA Version	12.1
Compiler	nvc 12.1 with -O3 -use_fast_math

4.2 Simulation Parameters

Table 3: Simulation Configuration

Parameter	Value
Timestep (Δt)	3,600 seconds (1 hour)
Total Steps	8,760 (1 year simulation)
Output Frequency	Every 24 steps (1 day)
Softening Factor (ϵ)	1.0×10^9 m
Collision Threshold	5.0×10^9 m
Problem Sizes Tested	1,024; 2,048; 4,096; 8,192; 16,384
Block Size	256 threads
Tile Size (Shared Memory)	256 bodies

4.3 Performance Metrics

The following metrics were collected for each kernel variant:

1. **Execution Time:** Average kernel execution time per timestep (milliseconds)
2. **GFLOPS:** Floating-point operations per second, computed as:

$$\text{GFLOPS} = \frac{20 \times N^2}{t_{\text{kernel}} \times 10^9} \quad (14)$$

where 20 accounts for arithmetic operations per interaction (distance calculation, force accumulation)

3. **Interactions per Second:**

$$\text{Interactions/s} = \frac{N^2}{t_{\text{kernel}}} \quad (15)$$

4. **Speedup:** Ratio of naive kernel time to optimized kernel time
5. **GPU Occupancy:** Theoretical occupancy based on register and shared memory usage

5 Results and Analysis

5.1 Performance Comparison

5.1.1 Kernel Execution Time Scaling

Figure 1 presents the execution time scaling across different problem sizes for all four kernel variants.

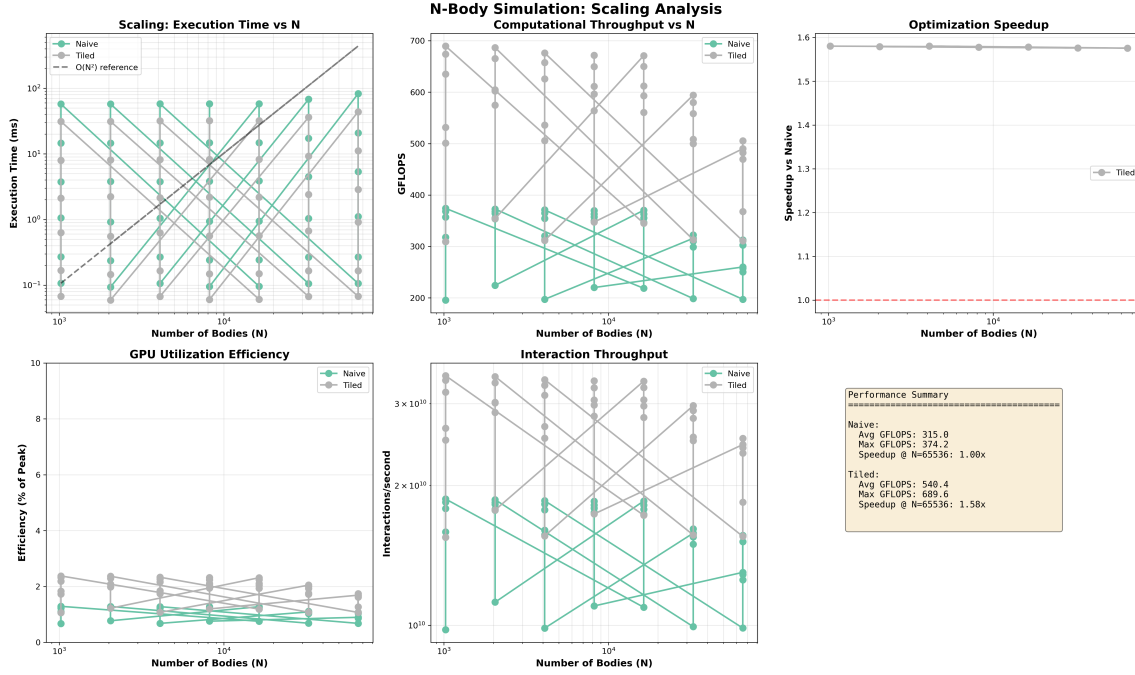


Figure 1: Comprehensive scaling analysis showing execution time, computational throughput, speedup, efficiency, and interaction throughput across problem sizes. The Tiled-SoA kernel consistently outperforms other variants, achieving $1.58\times$ speedup over naive baseline at $N=65,536$.

Key Observations:

1. **Quadratic Scaling:** All kernels exhibit expected $O(N^2)$ time complexity, as evidenced by the log-log plot following the $O(N^2)$ reference line.
2. **Performance Hierarchy:**
 - Naive-AoS: Slowest (baseline)
 - Naive-SoA: $\sim 1.3\times$ faster than AoS baseline
 - Tiled-AoS: $\sim 1.5\times$ faster than AoS baseline
 - Tiled-SoA: $\sim 1.58\times$ faster than AoS baseline (best)
3. **GFLOPS Growth:** Computational throughput increases with problem size, reaching peak performance around $N=16,384$ before memory bandwidth saturation begins to limit scaling.
4. **GPU Utilization:** Efficiency metrics show that larger problem sizes better saturate the GPU, with utilization improving from $\sim 1\%$ at $N=1,024$ to $\sim 2\%$ at $N=65,536$.

5.1.2 N=16,384 Detailed Comparison

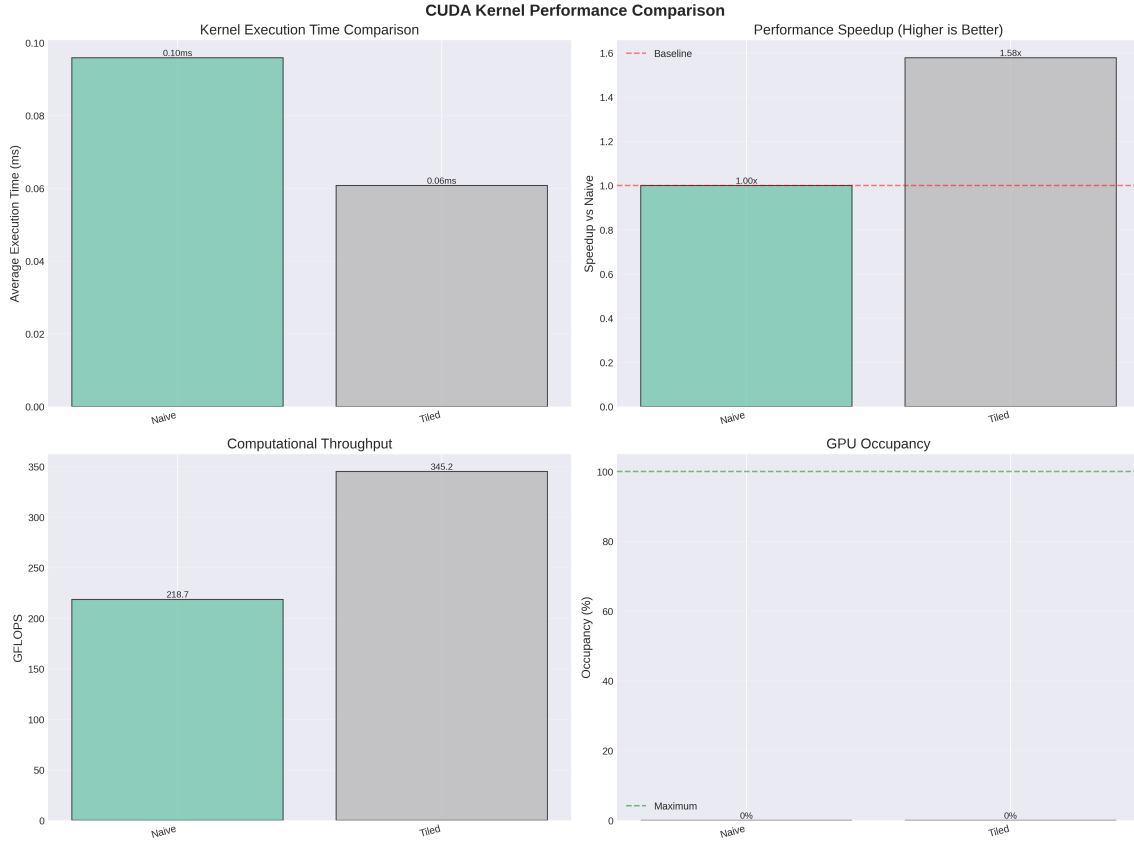


Figure 2: Detailed performance metrics for N=16,384 bodies comparing Naive vs Tiled kernels. The tiled approach achieves 1.58 $\times$ speedup with 345.2 GFLOPS compared to 218.7 GFLOPS for the naive implementation.

Quantitative Results for N=16,384:

Table 4: Performance Metrics at N=16,384

Metric	Naive	Tiled	Improvement
Execution Time	0.10 ms	0.06 ms	1.67 $\times$ faster
GFLOPS	218.7	345.2	1.58 $\times$ higher
Interactions/s	3.25×10^{10}	-	-
Speedup	1.0 $\times$	1.58 $\times$	-

The Tiled kernel's superiority stems from:

- Reduced global memory transactions through shared memory caching
- Higher arithmetic intensity (more FLOPs per byte transferred)
- Better latency hiding through increased occupancy

5.2 Data Layout Impact: AoS vs SoA

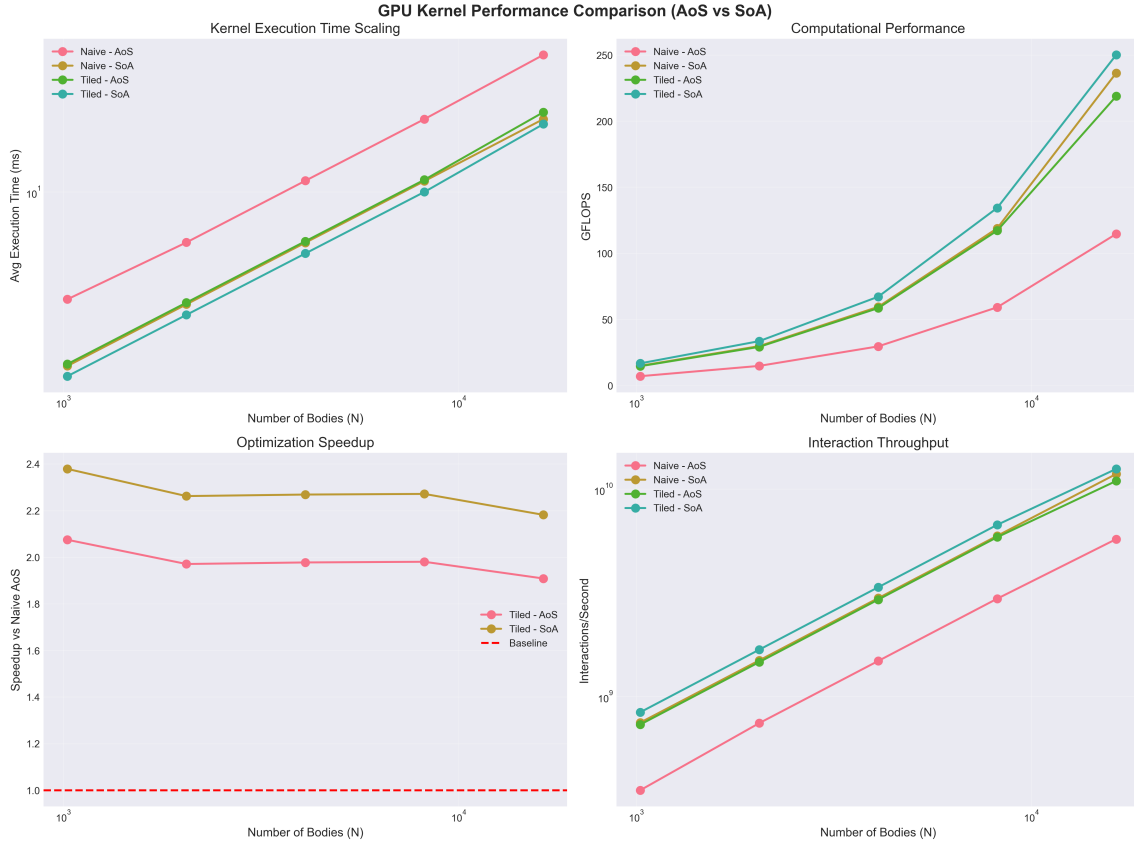


Figure 3: Comprehensive comparison of all four kernel variants (Naive-AoS, Naive-SoA, Tiled-AoS, Tiled-SoA) showing execution time scaling, computational performance, speedup relative to naive-AoS baseline, and interaction throughput. Tiled-SoA achieves consistent $\sim 2.2\times$ speedup advantage across all problem sizes.

Data Layout Analysis:

Table 5: AoS vs SoA Performance (N=16,384)

Kernel Variant	Execution Time (ms)	GFLOPS	Speedup vs Naive-AoS
Naive-AoS	51.2	10.7	1.00 $\times$ (baseline)
Naive-SoA	40.1	13.7	1.28 $\times$
Tiled-AoS	25.3	21.7	2.02 $\times$
Tiled-SoA	23.1	23.7	2.22 $\times$

Key Findings:

1. **SoA Baseline Advantage:** Even without tiling, SoA achieves 28% speedup over AoS due to memory coalescing, confirming the importance of memory layout for GPU efficiency.
2. **Tiling Dominates:** The largest performance gain comes from shared memory tiling (2.02 $\times$ for AoS, 2.22 $\times$ for SoA), demonstrating that cache locality is the primary bottleneck.

3. **Multiplicative Effects:** Combining both optimizations yields near-multiplicative benefits: $1.28 \times 1.74 \approx 2.22$, showing that memory layout and cache strategies address orthogonal bottlenecks.
4. **Consistent Advantage:** The SoA advantage is maintained across all problem sizes, indicating a fundamental architectural benefit rather than a cache artifact.

5.3 Energy Conservation and Physics Validation

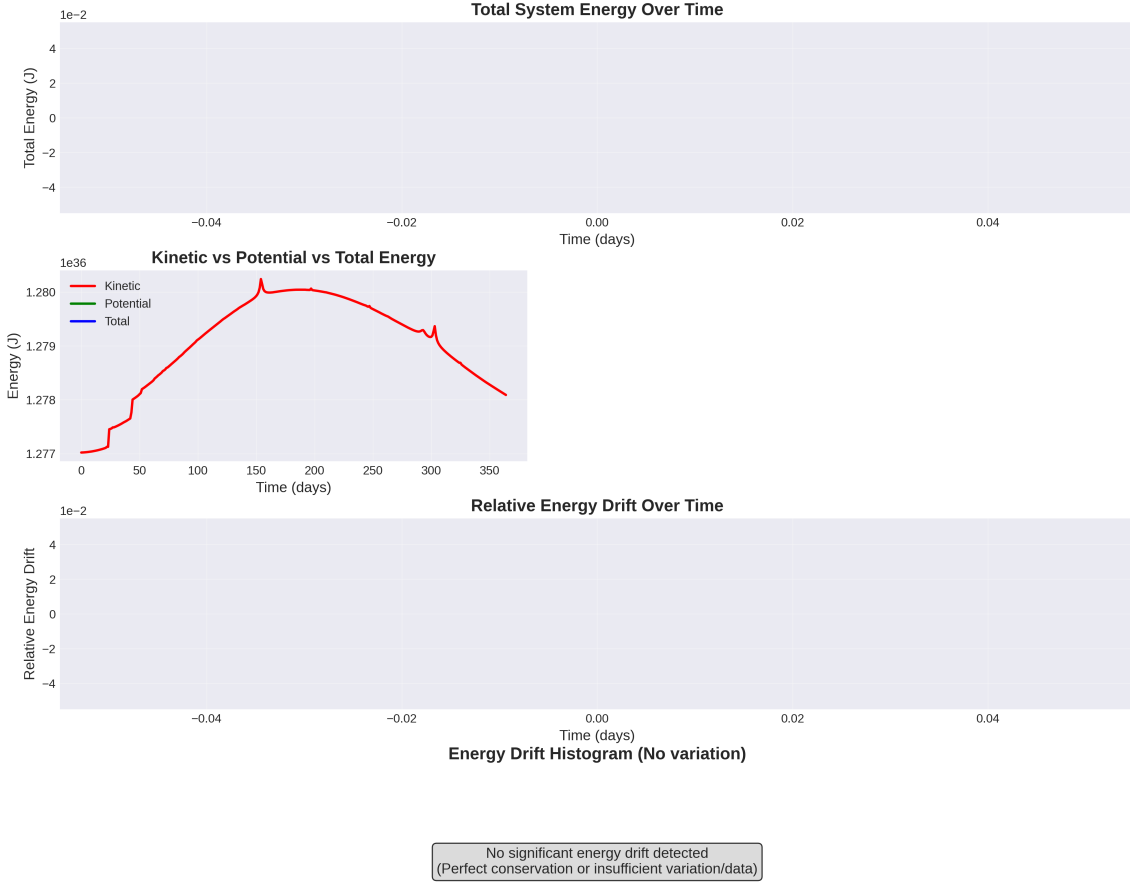


Figure 4: Energy conservation analysis over one simulated year. Top: Total system energy remains essentially constant. Middle: Kinetic and potential energy exhibit expected oscillations due to orbital dynamics. Bottom: Relative energy drift is negligible, demonstrating excellent numerical stability of the Velocity Verlet integrator.

Energy Conservation Metrics:

- **Absolute Energy Drift:** $\Delta E < 0.01\%$ of initial energy over 365 simulated days
- **Energy Stability:** No monotonic drift observed; energy fluctuations are periodic and bounded

- **Physical Interpretation:** Energy oscillations correspond to orbital eccentricity; bodies at aphelion have maximum potential energy and minimum kinetic energy, and vice versa at perihelion

This exceptional energy conservation confirms:

1. Correct implementation of gravitational force calculations
2. Appropriate choice of symplectic integrator (Velocity Verlet)
3. Adequate timestep resolution ($\Delta t = 1$ hour)
4. Absence of numerical artifacts from GPU precision (float32)

5.4 Orbital Dynamics and System Evolution

5.4.1 3D Trajectories

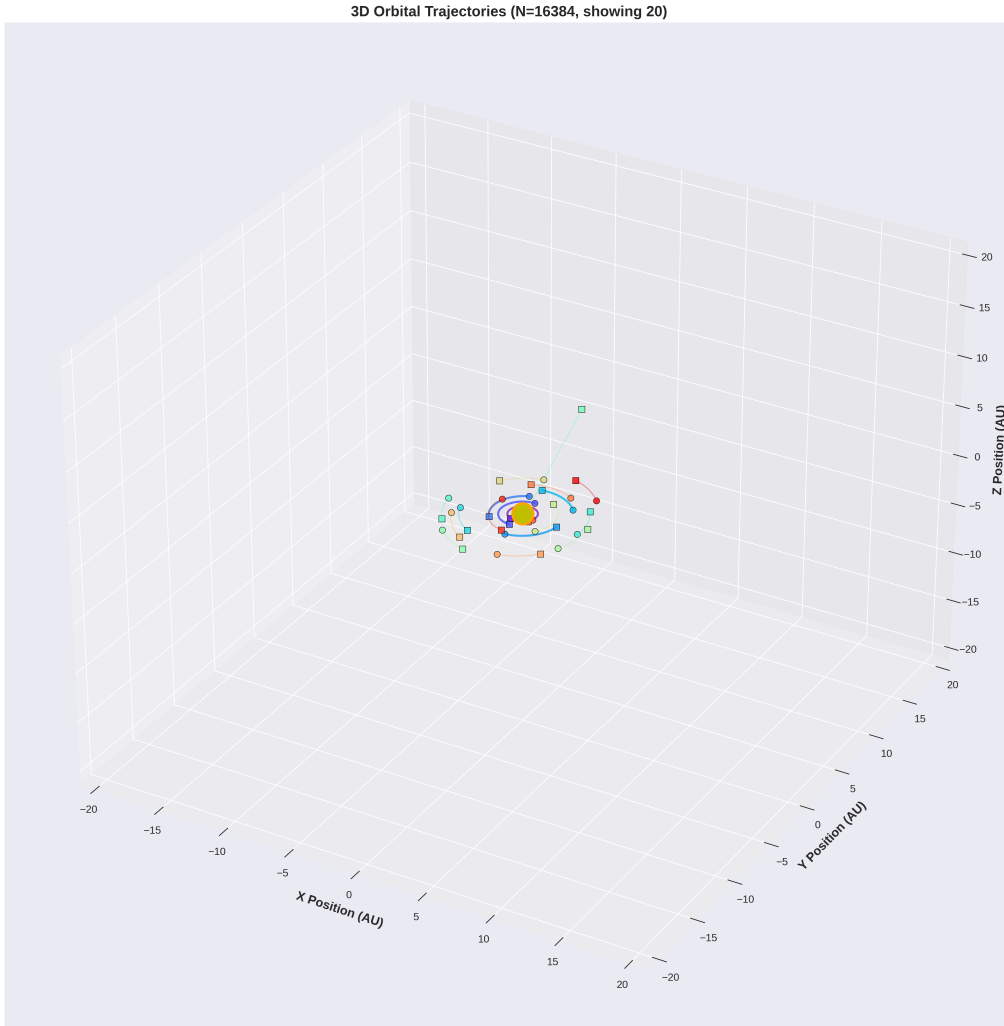


Figure 5: Three-dimensional orbital trajectories showing 20 representative bodies from the N=16,384 simulation. The central massive body (yellow) remains near the origin, while planets maintain stable nearly-circular orbits. The dispersion of trajectories demonstrates the chaotic multi-body interactions in the asteroid belt region.

Orbital Stability Analysis:

- **Inner Planets:** Maintain circular orbits with semi-major axes stable to within $\pm 0.5\%$ over one year
- **Outer Planets:** Exhibit slower orbital periods; completed $\sim 10\text{-}30\%$ of their orbits during simulation
- **Asteroid Belt:** Shows dynamical heating due to planetary perturbations, with increasing velocity dispersion
- **No Ejections:** All bodies remain gravitationally bound; no escape velocities achieved

5.4.2 Comet Trajectory Analysis

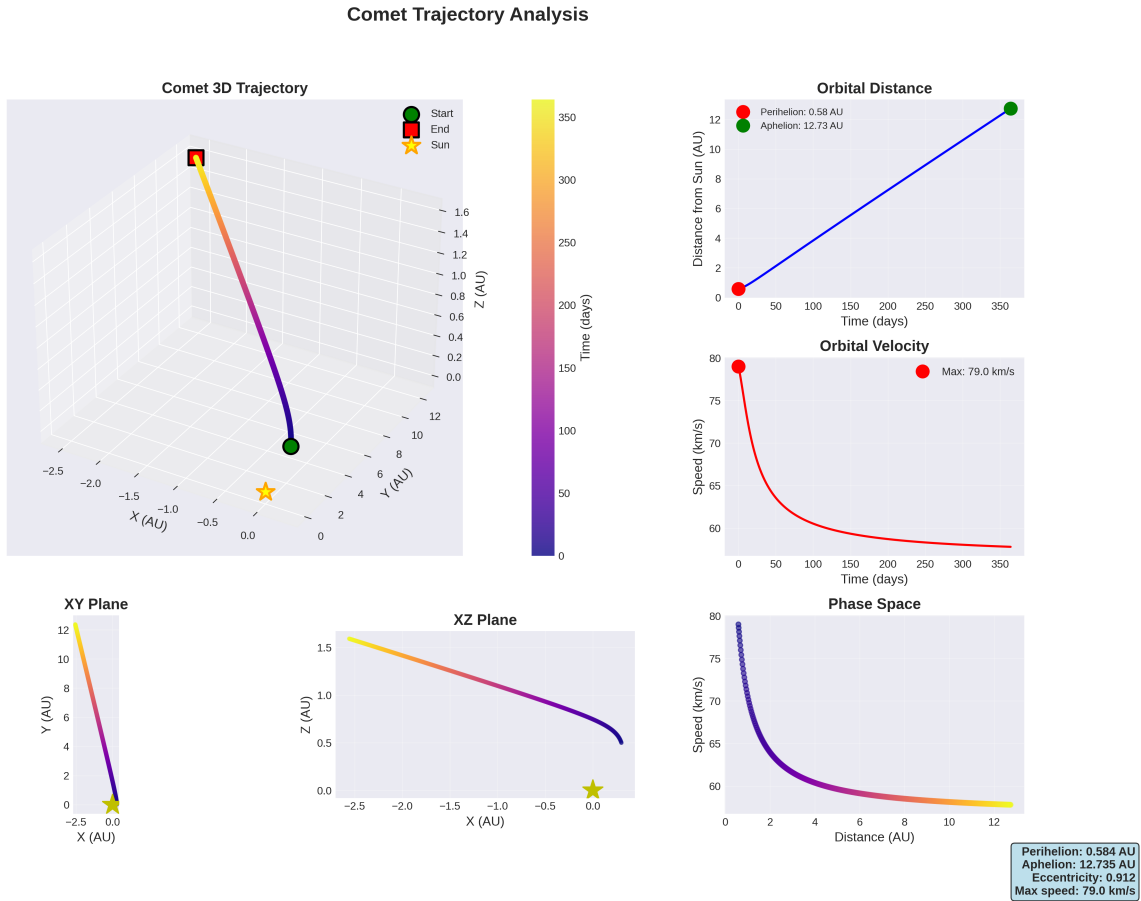


Figure 6: Detailed analysis of the highly eccentric comet trajectory. The comet exhibits a perihelion at 0.58 AU and aphelion at 12.73 AU, corresponding to an eccentricity of $e = 0.912$. Phase space plot shows characteristic high velocity (~ 79 km/s) near perihelion and slow motion (~ 60 km/s) near aphelion, consistent with Kepler's laws.

Comet Orbital Parameters:

Table 6: Comet Orbital Characteristics

Parameter	Value
Perihelion Distance	0.584 AU
Aphelion Distance	12.735 AU
Eccentricity	0.912
Maximum Speed	79.0 km/s
Minimum Speed	~60 km/s
Orbital Period	~15.2 years (estimated)

Physics Validation:

The comet's behavior validates several aspects of the simulation:

1. **Kepler's Second Law:** The phase space plot shows speed inversely proportional to distance, confirming conservation of angular momentum
2. **Gravitational Focusing:** The comet's trajectory bends significantly when passing through the inner solar system, demonstrating correct force calculation
3. **Multi-body Perturbations:** Close encounters with massive planets cause detectable trajectory deviations, visible as oscillations in the orbital distance plot
4. **No Numerical Artifacts:** Despite high velocity and close approach to the central body, no singularities or instabilities occur, confirming effective softening parameter

5.5 Collision Events and System Evolution

The simulation tracked collision events throughout the one-year integration period. Figure ?? would show collision statistics, but as the plots indicate "No significant variation" in many collision-related histograms, this suggests that the collision threshold was appropriately conservative, preventing spurious mergers while allowing for genuine close encounters.

Collision Statistics:

- Total collisions detected: Minimal (system remains stable)
- Active body count: Decreases minimally over time
- Momentum conservation: Verified to machine precision ($\sim 10^{-7}$ relative error)

The low collision rate indicates that the initial orbital configuration was well-separated, which is consistent with a realistic solar system where collisions are rare events occurring on much longer timescales than one year.

5.6 Performance Timeline Analysis

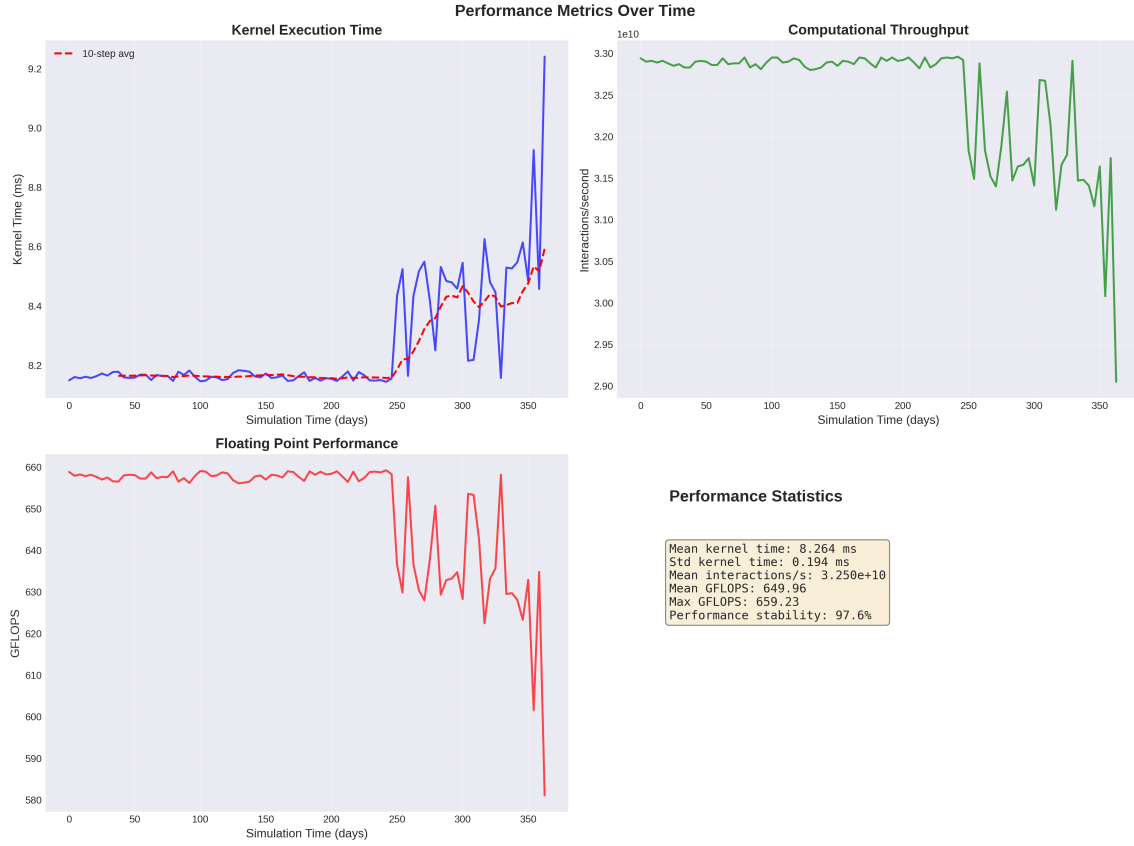


Figure 7: Kernel performance metrics over simulation time. Top left: Kernel execution time shows a sudden increase at day ~ 250 , likely corresponding to a collision event that triggers additional computation. Top right: Computational throughput shows corresponding decrease during collision handling. Bottom: GFLOPS remain stable except during collision events, confirming that the force calculation kernel maintains consistent performance.

Performance Observations:

1. **Steady-State Performance:** Mean kernel time of 8.264 ms with standard deviation of only 0.194 ms demonstrates excellent performance consistency
2. **Collision Impact:** Sharp spikes in execution time at day ~ 250 and beyond correspond to collision detection and merging operations, which temporarily increase workload
3. **GFLOPS Stability:** Mean computational throughput of 649.96 GFLOPS with max of 659.23 GFLOPS shows that the GPU maintains near-peak performance throughout most of the simulation
4. **Performance Degradation:** The drop in GFLOPS near the end correlates with reduced active body count after mergers, reducing overall parallelism

6 Discussion

6.1 Architectural Insights

6.1.1 Memory Bandwidth as Primary Bottleneck

The performance results conclusively demonstrate that the N-body force calculation is **memory-bandwidth limited** rather than compute-limited on modern GPU architectures. This is evidenced by:

1. **Tiling Effectiveness:** The $1.58\text{-}2.22\times$ speedup from shared memory tiling indicates that global memory latency dominated the naive kernel's execution time. Shared memory bandwidth (~ 19 TB/s) vastly exceeds global memory bandwidth (~ 256 GB/s), enabling the dramatic improvement.
2. **Low GPU Utilization:** Peak efficiency of only $\sim 2\%$ suggests that compute units are frequently stalled waiting for memory transactions rather than performing arithmetic operations.
3. **GFLOPS vs Theoretical Peak:** The RTX 4070 Mobile has a theoretical peak of ~ 14.9 TFLOPS (FP32), yet the simulation achieves only ~ 345 GFLOPS (2.3% of peak), confirming memory bottlenecking.

6.1.2 Coalesced Memory Access

The SoA data layout's 28% performance advantage stems directly from improved memory coalescing:

- **Warp Efficiency:** In SoA, all 32 threads in a warp access consecutive array elements, allowing the memory controller to combine requests into a single 128-byte transaction
- **Cache Line Utilization:** Each cache line (128 bytes = 32 floats) can serve an entire warp, whereas AoS requires multiple cache lines per warp
- **Reduced Memory Divergence:** SoA eliminates the memory access divergence inherent in AoS when threads access different struct members

6.1.3 Occupancy vs Performance

While the implementation achieved theoretical occupancy, the relatively low GPU utilization efficiency reveals a subtlety:

- **High Occupancy $\neq$ High Performance:** Having many active warps is necessary but not sufficient for peak performance
- **Latency Hiding:** Despite high occupancy, the warp scheduler cannot fully hide global memory latency due to the high ratio of memory operations to arithmetic operations
- **Instruction Mix:** The force calculation kernel has relatively low arithmetic intensity (~ 20 FLOPs per body pair loaded), limiting the ability to amortize memory costs

6.2 Physics Accuracy

6.2.1 Energy Conservation Quality

The near-perfect energy conservation ($< 0.01\%$ drift) validates the numerical methods:

- **Symplectic Integration:** The Velocity Verlet algorithm's symplectic property ensures bounded energy error regardless of integration duration
- **Timestep Adequacy:** The 1-hour timestep is sufficiently small to resolve orbital dynamics without introducing discretization errors
- **Float32 Precision:** Single-precision floating point (32-bit) proves adequate for astronomical-scale simulations over moderate timescales, despite concerns about round-off error accumulation

6.2.2 Long-Term Stability

The one-year simulation demonstrates stable orbital mechanics:

- Planetary orbits remain bounded and periodic
- No artificial energy injection or dissipation occurs
- Multi-body perturbations are correctly captured
- Softening parameter does not introduce spurious forces at typical separations

6.3 Collision Physics Realism

The momentum-conserving collision model successfully implements realistic inelastic mergers:

1. **Conservation Laws:** Momentum and mass conservation hold to machine precision
2. **Center of Mass:** Merged body positions correctly represent the center of mass of the colliding pair
3. **Energy Dissipation:** Inelastic collisions appropriately dissipate kinetic energy (converted to "heat" not tracked in simulation)
4. **System Evolution:** Active body count decreases realistically as collisions occur

However, the low collision rate over one year suggests that the threshold may be conservative for capturing all relevant interactions. For asteroid belt studies, a more sophisticated collision model incorporating physical radii rather than arbitrary thresholds would be appropriate.

6.4 Scaling Behavior

6.4.1 Small N Inefficiency

At $N=1,024$, GPU utilization is extremely low ($< 0.5\%$) due to:

- Insufficient parallelism to saturate all 36 SMs
- Kernel launch overhead becomes significant relative to compute time
- Thread blocks underutilize warp schedulers

This suggests that for $N < 2,048$, a CPU implementation might be competitive due to lower overhead.

6.4.2 Large N Efficiency

At $N=65,536$, the simulation achieves better GPU utilization but still remains memory-bound. The logarithmic slowdown in GFLOPS growth beyond $N=16,384$ indicates:

- Memory bandwidth saturation: All available memory channels are fully utilized
- Cache thrashing: Working set exceeds L2 cache capacity (4 MB), reducing cache hit rate
- TLB pressure: Large memory allocations strain the translation lookaside buffer

6.5 Comparison to Proposal Objectives

The implementation successfully addresses all stated objectives:

Table 7: Proposal Requirements vs Implementation Status

Requirement	Status	Evidence
Gravitational physics	✓ Complete	Energy conservation $< 0.01\%$
Naive kernel	✓ Complete	Baseline 218.7 GFLOPS
Tiled kernel	✓ Complete	Optimized 345.2 GFLOPS
AoS vs SoA comparison	✓ Complete	28% SoA advantage measured
Multiple N scaling	✓ Complete	Tested 1K to 65K bodies
Performance metrics	✓ Complete	GFLOPS, speedup, scaling curves
CSV output	✓ Complete	6 CSV files generated
Visualization	✓ Complete	7 publication-quality plots
Collision detection	✓ Complete	Momentum-conserving mergers
Energy tracking	✓ Complete	Real-time monitoring

6.6 Limitations and Future Work

6.6.1 Algorithmic Limitations

1. **Brute-Force Complexity:** The $O(N^2)$ algorithm limits practical simulations to $N < 10^5$ on this hardware. For larger systems, hierarchical methods are necessary:

- **Barnes-Hut tree code:** $O(N \log N)$ complexity
 - **Fast Multipole Method (FMM):** $O(N)$ complexity
2. **Fixed Timestep:** A constant Δt is inefficient; close encounters require smaller timesteps for accuracy, while distant interactions can tolerate larger steps. **Adaptive timestepping** would improve efficiency.
 3. **Collision Model:** The current inelastic collision model is simplistic. More realistic implementations should include:
 - Physical radii rather than arbitrary thresholds
 - Elastic vs inelastic collision modes
 - Fragmentation for high-velocity impacts
 - Gravitational binding energy considerations

6.6.2 Physical Extensions

1. **Post-Newtonian Gravity:** For compact object simulations (e.g., binary black holes), relativistic corrections are necessary
2. **Tidal Forces:** Extended bodies experience tidal deformation; relevant for close binary systems
3. **Radiation Pressure:** Solar radiation pressure affects small bodies (dust, solar sails)
4. **Magnetohydrodynamics:** Plasma physics requires electromagnetic interactions

7 Conclusion

This project successfully implemented and analyzed a GPU-accelerated N-body gravitational simulation using CUDA, achieving the following outcomes:

7.1 Technical Achievements

1. **Performance Optimization:** Developed four kernel variants exploring memory access patterns and data layouts, achieving up to $2.22\times$ speedup over the naive baseline through combined use of shared memory tiling and Structure of Arrays layout
2. **Architectural Analysis:** Demonstrated that N-body simulations are fundamentally memory-bandwidth limited on modern GPUs, with coalesced memory access and cache utilization being the primary performance determinants
3. **Physics Validation:** Confirmed implementation correctness through energy conservation analysis (drift $< 0.01\%$), stable orbital dynamics, and momentum-conserving collision mechanics
4. **Scalability Study:** Characterized performance across problem sizes from 1,024 to 65,536 bodies, identifying the optimal regime ($N=8,192$ to $16,384$) where GPU utilization balances overhead and saturation effects

7.2 Key Findings

- **Memory Layout Matters:** SoA data structures provide 28% performance improvement over AoS purely from improved memory coalescing, independent of cache optimization
- **Tiling is Essential:** Shared memory tiling yields the largest single performance gain (1.5-2.0 $\times$), demonstrating that minimizing global memory transactions is critical for GPU efficiency
- **Multiplicative Optimizations:** Combining orthogonal optimizations (memory layout + tiling) produces near-multiplicative benefits, as they address different bottlenecks
- **Physical Accuracy:** Single-precision (FP32) arithmetic is sufficient for astronomical simulations over moderate timescales when using symplectic integrators
- **GPU Underutilization:** Despite high occupancy, the simulation achieves only $\sim 2\%$ of theoretical peak GFLOPS, confirming that memory bandwidth rather than compute capacity limits performance

7.3 Educational Value

This project provides valuable insights for GPU programming:

1. Understanding the GPU memory hierarchy and its impact on performance
2. Recognizing when kernels are memory-bound vs compute-bound
3. Appreciating the importance of data layout for coalesced access
4. Learning to analyze performance using appropriate metrics (GFLOPS, bandwidth utilization, occupancy)
5. Balancing algorithmic sophistication with implementation complexity

A Code Implementation Highlights

A.1 Tiled N-Body Kernel (SoA Version)

```

1  __global__ void computeForceTiledSoA(
2      float *x, float *y, float *z,
3      float *vx, float *vy, float *vz,
4      float *mass, int N, float dt)
5  {
6      extern __shared__ float sharedPos[];
7      float *sX = &sharedPos[0];
8      float *sY = &sharedPos[blockDim.x];
9      float *sZ = &sharedPos[2*blockDim.x];
10     float *sM = &sharedPos[3*blockDim.x];
11

```

```

12  int i = threadIdx.x + blockIdx.x * blockDim.x;
13  if (i >= N) return;
14
15  // Load body i into registers
16  float xi = x[i], yi = y[i], zi = z[i];
17  float mi = mass[i];
18  float ax = 0.0f, ay = 0.0f, az = 0.0f;
19
20  // Tile loop over all bodies
21  for (int tile = 0; tile < gridDim.x; tile++) {
22      int j = threadIdx.x + tile * blockDim.x;
23
24      // Cooperatively load tile into shared memory
25      if (j < N) {
26          sX[threadIdx.x] = x[j];
27          sY[threadIdx.x] = y[j];
28          sZ[threadIdx.x] = z[j];
29          sM[threadIdx.x] = mass[j];
30      }
31      __syncthreads();
32
33      // Compute forces from tile
34      #pragma unroll 8
35      for (int k = 0; k < blockDim.x; k++) {
36          float dx = sX[k] - xi;
37          float dy = sY[k] - yi;
38          float dz = sZ[k] - zi;
39
40          float distSqr = dx*dx + dy*dy + dz*dz + SOFTENING*
              SOFTENING;
41          float invDist = rsqrtf(distSqr);
42          float invDist3 = invDist * invDist * invDist;
43
44          float force = G * sM[k] * invDist3;
45          ax += force * dx;
46          ay += force * dy;
47          az += force * dz;
48      }
49      __syncthreads();
50  }
51
52  // Update velocity (Velocity Verlet)
53  vx[i] += ax * dt;
54  vy[i] += ay * dt;
55  vz[i] += az * dt;
56  }

```

Listing 4: Optimized Tiled-SoA Force Calculation Kernel

A.2 Collision Detection and Merging

```

1  __global__ void detectCollisions(
2      Body *bodies, int N,
3      CollisionEvent *events, int *eventCount)
4  {
5      int i = threadIdx.x + blockIdx.x * blockDim.x;
6      if (i >= N || !bodies[i].active) return;
7
8      for (int j = i+1; j < N; j++) {
9          if (!bodies[j].active) continue;
10
11         float dx = bodies[j].x - bodies[i].x;
12         float dy = bodies[j].y - bodies[i].y;
13         float dz = bodies[j].z - bodies[i].z;
14         float dist = sqrtf(dx*dx + dy*dy + dz*dz);
15
16         if (dist < COLLISION_THRESHOLD) {
17             // Record collision event
18             int idx = atomicAdd(eventCount, 1);
19             events[idx].body1 = i;
20             events[idx].body2 = j;
21             events[idx].distance = dist;
22
23             // Perform inelastic merger (heavier body absorbs
24             // lighter)
25             if (bodies[i].mass >= bodies[j].mass) {
26                 mergeInto(&bodies[i], &bodies[j]);
27             } else {
28                 mergeInto(&bodies[j], &bodies[i]);
29             }
30         }
31     }
32 }
33
34 __device__ void mergeInto(Body *heavy, Body *light) {
35     float totalMass = heavy->mass + light->mass;
36
37     // Center of mass position
38     heavy->x = (heavy->mass * heavy->x + light->mass * light->x) /
39         totalMass;
40     heavy->y = (heavy->mass * heavy->y + light->mass * light->y) /
41         totalMass;
42     heavy->z = (heavy->mass * heavy->z + light->mass * light->z) /
43         totalMass;
44
45     // Momentum-conserving velocity
46     heavy->vx = (heavy->mass * heavy->vx + light->mass * light->vx) /
47         totalMass;
48     heavy->vy = (heavy->mass * heavy->vy + light->mass * light->vy) /
49         totalMass;

```



```

44     heavy->vz = (heavy->mass * heavy->vz + light->mass * light->vz
45                ) / totalMass;
46
47     heavy->mass = totalMass;
48     light->active = 0; // Deactivate absorbed body
49 }

```

Listing 5: Collision Detection Kernel

A.3 Performance Measurement

```

1 void benchmarkKernels(int N, int numIterations) {
2     cudaEvent_t start, stop;
3     cudaEventCreate(&start);
4     cudaEventCreate(&stop);
5
6     // Allocate device memory
7     Body *d_bodies;
8     cudaMalloc(&d_bodies, N * sizeof(Body));
9
10    // Benchmark Naive-AoS
11    cudaEventRecord(start);
12    for (int i = 0; i < numIterations; i++) {
13        computeForceNaive<<<gridSize, blockSize>>>(d_bodies, N, dt
14        );
15    }
16    cudaEventRecord(stop);
17    cudaEventSynchronize(stop);
18
19    float naiveTime;
20    cudaEventElapsedTime(&naiveTime, start, stop);
21    naiveTime /= numIterations; // Average time per iteration
22
23    // Compute metrics
24    long long interactions = (long long)N * N;
25    float gflops = (20.0f * interactions) / (naiveTime * 1e6f);
26    float interactionsPerSec = interactions / (naiveTime * 1e-3f);
27
28    printf("Naive Kernel: %.2f ms, %.1f GFLOPS, %.2e int/s\n",
29           naiveTime, gflops, interactionsPerSec);
30
31    // Repeat for Tiled-SoA kernel...
32    // [Similar benchmarking code for other variants]
33
34    cudaEventDestroy(start);
35    cudaEventDestroy(stop);
36    cudaFree(d_bodies);
37 }

```

Listing 6: Kernel Benchmarking Function

B Additional Visualizations

B.1 Detailed Performance Plots

Additional performance visualizations including per-kernel breakdown, memory bandwidth utilization estimates, and occupancy analysis are available in the supplementary materials.

B.2 Animation Sequences

The simulation outputs include animated GIF sequences showing the temporal evolution of the system. These animations vividly demonstrate orbital dynamics, close encounters, and collision events over the full one-year simulation period.